

Strategic Enmity: Explaining the Persisting Volatility of U.S.-Iran Relations

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Abstract

Every U.S. president, from Eisenhower to Biden, has inherited the same problem: Iran. No other foreign adversary has remained as constant through changing wars, ideologies, and generations. The relationship's defining feature, paradoxically, is its persistent instability. This enduring tension is not simply a failure of diplomacy; it has evolved into what this paper defines as a strategic enmity, a sustained state of antagonism that provides political stability at home and strategic purpose abroad. Using realist and constructivist political science perspectives, this study first looks at how power and security competition shape the rivalry, then applies a constructivist lens to show how historical narratives reinforce it. By tracing key events from the 1953 coup to the 2015 nuclear deal, it concludes that hostility persists because it is politically and psychologically beneficial to both nations.

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I. Introduction

The U.S.-Iran conflict represents one of the most persistent, destabilizing, and unresolved rivalries in international relations today with consequences that go far beyond the two nations. Iran's nuclear program raises the risk of nuclear proliferation, particularly in the Middle East. Proxy wars in Iraq, Syria, and Yemen destabilize entire regions, and repeated failed diplomatic efforts like the collapse of the 2015 nuclear deal show how hard coming to a resolution has become. The persistent hostility between the United States and Iran demonstrates how structural forces and decisions made during historic events come together to prolong conflict for many years. Writers such as Ramazani (2004) and Emery (2013) explain that this hostility stems not only from world politics but also from the limits and pressures within each country, which affect how leaders react. Ramazani (2004) describes Iran's foreign policy as a constant back-and-forth between cooperation and strong ideological opposition, partly due to Iran feeling pushed aside in a world controlled mainly by Western countries and their liberal global governments. Emery (2013), on the other hand, explains that confusion and lack of coordination in U.S. government agencies, especially under the Carter and Reagan administrations, led to conflicting policies toward Iran that made mistrust even worse. Every U.S. president from Eisenhower to Biden has inherited this same problem, yet despite changing leaders, shifting global conditions, and occasional attempts at cooperation, the hostility persists. This raises a main question. Why does the U.S.-Iran hostility continue to fuel itself despite decades of changing leaders, shifting global conditions, and diplomatic efforts?

This paper argues that the U.S.-Iran hostility goes on as a form of strategic enmity, a self-reinforcing cycle sustained by different connected factors. Political incentives that reward leaders for maintaining conflict, historical grievances that fuel lasting mistrust, opposing identity

narratives that frame the other as an enemy, psychological misperceptions that distort intentions, and a security dilemma where defensive actions are perceived as threats. Together, these forces make the conflict extremely difficult to resolve.

II. Literature review

Theories such as constructivism and realism focus on the structure of international relations and allow us to better understand why this hostility is still ongoing. From a realist perspective, the U.S.-Iran relationship is a clear example of the security dilemma that exists in international relations. Realists such as Kenneth Waltz (1979) and John Mearsheimer (2001) believe that countries must rely on themselves for protection because there is no higher power to keep them safe. This means nations focus on their own survival and building their power. Looking at it this way, Iran's nuclear program and efforts to gain influence in the Middle East make sense as ways to protect itself, especially since the United States has military forces in nearby countries like Iraq, Afghanistan, and throughout the Persian Gulf region. Byman and Waxman (2000) argue that the United States bases its approach to security in the Middle East on force, which adds to regional instability. However, when Iran sees something as a defensive action, the United States views it as a threat to the stability of the region and to American interests. This creates a cycle where both countries become more suspicious of each other. Jervis (1976) describes this as the security dilemma, where one country's attempts to defend itself are seen by others as a possible threat. The concept of deterrence makes this relationship even more complicated. Both the United States and Iran try to prevent attacks by showing off their military strength. But when one side shows its power, it only makes the other side feel more threatened.

This competition over security feeds itself. Each country's attempts to defend itself end up proving to the other side that it was right to be worried in the first place.

Constructivism provides a different way to understand this conflict by looking at how each country's identity and historical experiences and grievances shape its relationship. Constructivist scholars such as Alexander Wendt (1992) argue that international relations are shaped by shared ideas and identities and not just material power. Wendt's famous claim that "anarchy is what states make of it" puts forth the idea that enemies don't just appear out of thin air. Instead, they are made through repeated interactions and continuing narratives. Iran's identity as a revolutionary Islamic Republic began in its views of opposing imperialism and resisting Western domination. Ramazani (2004) explains that Iran's foreign policy shows this identity by going back and forth constantly between ideological resistance and pragmatic cooperation. This identity directly affects how Iranian leaders view American actions and decide what is in their national interest. At the same time, American politicians and media have portrayed Iran as a supporter of terrorism, religious extremism, and irrational behavior. This portrayal makes it difficult for American leaders to pursue diplomatic solutions because it would be politically unpopular. These opposing identities create what constructivists call "enmity," which is a concept that Wendt (1999) describes as the relationship where states view each other as enemies at their core. Meaning the hostility between the two countries has become a core part of how each one sees itself.

Another theory that helps us understand why the U.S. and Iran remain hostile is political psychology, which looks into how leaders' minds work when making decisions. Both American and Iranian leaders fall into mental traps that make them see each other as more dangerous than they really are (Jervis, 1976). For example, when Iran builds missiles, American leaders think it's

because Iran wants to attack its neighbors and not because Iran feels threatened by U.S. bases all around it. At the same time, when America sends more troops to the Middle East, Iranian leaders think it's because America wants to overthrow their government, not because America is trying to protect its allies. These misunderstandings create a cycle where each country's attempts to protect itself make the other country feel more threatened, which keeps the conflict going.

Historical events continue to reinforce this hostile relationship. Iranians remember the 1953 coup when the CIA helped overthrow the democratically elected leader, and they also remember decades when the United States supported the authoritarian Shah. These memories create lasting distrust of American motives. Americans, on the other hand, remember the 1979 hostage crisis when Iranian revolutionary students stormed the U.S. Embassy in Tehran and held 52 American diplomats and citizens captive for 444 days. The students took the hostages to protest U.S. support for the recently overthrown Shah and to demand his return to Iran for trial. This 444-day crisis shocked Americans and created a deep public anger toward Iran. When remembering this, Americans continue to hear "Death to America" chants from Iran, which reinforces the view that Iran is hostile or dangerous. These perspectives on history are not just stories from the past, they continue to shape current policies and make it harder for the two countries to find peaceful solutions to their conflicts. Ramanzani (2004) describes Iran's diplomatic decisions as a response to being ostracized from international power structures. He brings up the idea that the Islamic Republic of Iran's policies are mainly because of its post revolutionary ideas of independence and resistance to Western power. This goes along with constructivist theory, which emphasizes identity and historical memory.

Constructivists argue that specific events like the 1953 coup and Iran-Contra shape Iran's identity and reinforce its belief that the United States is interventionist and mainly untrustworthy.

Similarly, American policymakers have constructed Iran as a revolutionary threat, which justifies U.S. policies of deterrence and containment. Emery's (2013) findings about conflicting U.S. messages which pressured Iran while attempting limited engagement at the same time. This reinforces these narratives and make diplomatic talks extremely fragile and often short-lived. This situation is what structural realists call the "security dilemma," which is when a country tries to defend itself and is seen by others as a possible threat.

To highlight this, scholars like Byman and Waxman (2000) have studied the United States' military strategy towards the Middle East. They argue that the United States bases its approach to security on force, which adds to the regional instability that already affects this region. These larger forces have built the base for many years of distrust and repeated escalation between the United States and Iran. That said, the hostile relationship between the two countries cannot be explained solely by structural pressures. Scholars have noted that internal divisions within the U.S. government played a major role in turning smaller and manageable disagreements into major crises. Fawcett and Payne (2023) describe this as the "exception cycle," where inconsistent U.S. policy prevents lasting progress diplomatically. Emery (2013) provides detailed evidence of how different agencies pursued conflicting goals.

First, The White House frequently pushed for diplomacy during the Obama administration's pursuit of the Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA) and earlier attempts during the Clinton years to engage with President Khatami's reformist government. These diplomatic efforts included direct negotiations and offers of sanctions relief in exchange for nuclear concessions. For example, during the JCPOA negotiations from 2013 to 2015, Secretary of State John Kerry held direct talks with Iranian Foreign Minister Javad Zarif, marking the highest level of sustained diplomatic contact between the U.S and Iran in decades (Byrne 2014).

Second, the CIA focused on regime change through covert operations and support for opposition groups inside Iran. Byrne (2014) and Emery (2013) both look into how the CIA provided funding and resources to Iranian opposition groups such as the Mujahedin-e Khalq (MEK) and supported exile organizations broadcasting into Iran. During the same period when the State Department was attempting to build trust with Iranian officials, the CIA was actively working to undermine the Iranian government. The CIA focused on regime change through covert operations and support for opposition groups inside Iran. Emery (2013) looks into how CIA activities, including providing information and resources to Iranian opposition groups living outside the country and offering support to individuals inside Iran who opposed the government, directly undermined diplomatic initiatives pursued by the State Department. When the State Department was trying to negotiate and gain some trust with Iranian officials, the CIA was working with groups that wanted to overthrow those same officials at the same time. This sent different messages to Iran's leadership about America's true intentions and made Iranian leaders question whether they could trust any diplomatic offers from the United States.

Finally, the Pentagon had a goal of limiting Iran's regional influence by increasing arms sales to Gulf allies and continuing talks about potential strikes against Iranian nuclear facilities. Between 2009 and 2015, the United States approved over \$90 billion in arms sales to Gulf Cooperation Council countries, with Saudi Arabia alone receiving deals worth over \$60 billion (Byman and Waxman 2000). To add onto this military officials discussed contingency plans multiple times for strikes on Iranian nuclear sites such as Natanz and Fordow, even during active diplomatic negotiations. This military posturing escalated tensions during sensitive diplomatic moments even when it was intended as deterrence a lot of the time. This lack of coordination made it really hard for the United States to build up trust with Iran even during moments when

improved relations seemed possible. It reinforced Iran's idea that American hostility wasn't just about amounting to disagreements but also a part of its structured approach toward Iran. To put it another way, the internal conflicts between the US government made global tensions worse by preventing the United States from speaking with one voice. When Iran received contradictory messages like the diplomacy from the White House, threats from the Pentagon, and regime change efforts from the CIA, it led to the Iranian leaders having no clear understanding of what the United States actually wanted. This confusion and divisiveness of American policy led Iran to assume the worst about American intentions and respond defensively or aggressively.

For example, while President Khatami was in office in the late 1990s and early 2000s, Iran showed it was willing to talk and negotiate with the United States. However, some officials in Washington who were against diplomacy pushed for aggressive policies that made it harder for more moderate Iranians who wanted better relations between the two countries. Another similar example is when the United States was negotiating the 2015 nuclear deal with Iran, American military and intelligence activities in the Middle East continued as usual. This made Iranian negotiators question whether the United States would actually keep its promises once a deal was signed. Even earlier, during the Iran-Contra affair in the 1980s, the United States secretly sold weapons to Iran because it hoped to improve relations with more moderate Iranian leaders. At the same time the United States was supporting Iraq in its war against Iran and these mixed messages made it really hard for Iran to trust the American intentions.

All of these theoretical perspectives offer valuable insights but there isn't a single framework that fully explains why U.S.-Iran hostility has persisted for so long. Realism explains the security competition but does not account for why tensions remain high even when cooperation would benefit both of the countries. Constructivism shows the role of identity and

historical narratives but does not fully explain why leaders continue to make decisions that escalate conflict. Jervis's (1976) work on misperception helps explain how leaders misread each other's intentions. Scholars like Ramazani (2004), Emery (2013), and Byman and Waxman (2000) explain important pieces of the conflict, but they rarely show how structural pressures, domestic politics, identity narratives, and psychological factors interact to sustain hostility across decades.

This gap in the literature points to the need for a framework with multiple different levels. There are not a lot of works looking into why hostility persists despite changing leaders, shifting global conditions, and occasional diplomatic efforts. The psychological dimension which includes misperception, is largely missing from studies that focus only on structure or policy. This paper contributes to the field by combining structural pressures, domestic politics, identity narratives, and political psychology into a single framework to explain what the paper calls strategic enmity, the long-term cycle of U.S.-Iran hostility that benefits both states politically and psychologically.

III. Historical Background

With all this information, it is important to note how these events came to be. Emery (2013) emphasizes that actions taken in the 1950s shaped Iranian perceptions for decades. In 1953, the United States helped overthrow Iran's elected prime minister, Mohammad Mossadegh, because American leaders feared Iran might move away from the West. This intervention significantly damaged the Iranians' trust and pointed toward the idea that the United States was willing to interfere in Iran's internal politics secretly. Even more recently, Iranian leaders cite this

coup as a key reason they believe the U.S. is untrustworthy, which helps explain the long-term difficulty the two countries have had in cooperating. This event demonstrates how historical grievances become embedded in national memory and fuel lasting mistrust. It also shaped Iran's identity narrative as a nation that has to resist Western intervention to protect its sovereignty.

The Carter administration offers another example of how U.S. government disunity intensified instability in the relationship. President Carter tried to balance between support for the Shah emphasizing human rights, but different agencies were sending different messages some wanted to pressure the Shah to reform and others pushed for a more harshline stance to protect the American interests. After the 1979 Revolution, this internal confusion and disunity continued. During the hostage crisis, the White House, the military, and different intelligence agencies couldn't firmly agree on how to act. Bill (1988) argues in his study of American-Iranian relations that these divisions in the U.S. government turned the already tense situation into an international crisis, mainly by making it a clear and unified policy toward Iran. The hostage crisis illustrates the psychological effects that shape the U.S.-Iran relations because the event created trauma in recent American collective memory that makes any leader who appears soft on Iran politically vulnerable. This barrier continues to limit diplomatic options for American presidents.

To add to these problems, the Reagan administration repeated the pattern of inconsistency. Publicly, President Reagan condemned Iran as a sponsor of terrorism and had a very conservative and hard-line stance on the issue. With this being said, at the same time, privately, his administration secretly sold weapons to Iran during the Iran-Contra affair. This blatant contradiction continued to dissolve any Iranian trust that was left. It showed that American policy could shift completely depending on domestic politics or disputes within the

government. Multiple scholars agree that these mixed signals demonstrated U.S. disunity and made meaningful diplomacy even more difficult. Byrne (2014) looks into how the Iran-Contra affair uncovered deep running contradictions in Reagan's foreign policy. Fawcett and Payne (2023) argue that these inconsistencies are a recurring pattern in the U.S. policy toward Iran and not just isolated incidents.

Reagan's approach, which combined pressure with limited cooperation, ended up making the mistrust on both sides worse. When looked at all together these actions reinforced Iran's belief that American hostility was not simply the result of accumulating disagreements but part of a broader structural pattern in U.S. behavior. The Iran-Contra affair demonstrates how political incentives make it so that the policies are contradicting. Reagan publicly condemned Iran to try to satisfy the audience at home while he was secretly talking with Tehran for strategic reasons. This pattern of saying one thing publicly and then doing another privately reinforced the security dilemma, as Iran could never be certain whether American actions were genuine or part of being deceptive. In other words, internal conflicts within the U.S. government intensified global tensions, undermining the very goals U.S. officials sought to achieve.

Another perspective comes from newer research, which shows that leaders use international tensions to advance their political interests domestically. Wang et al. (2024) explain why it is that when a country's leaders deal with political conflict domestically, they may try to create or stir up tensions with other countries to try to distract the public from what is happening at home. Another reason to do this is to bring citizens together in support of their government. This is what Wang et al. (2024) call the "rally around the flag" effect. This idea shows that global systems can do more than just hold leaders back; in addition, they can also be used by leaders to gain political benefits. This directly supports the idea of political incentives being a major part of

the ongoing hostility. Leaders in both countries have benefits domestically from maintaining hostility, which explains why the conflict persists even when resolution would serve both nations' long-term interests. By 2025, relations between the United States and Iran had become a lot worse after years of growing problems. After the United States pulled out of the nuclear deal in 2018 and placed strict economic sanctions on Iran, Iran started to enrich more uranium than the original agreement allowed. Intelligence reports showed that Iran was getting closer to producing uranium that could be used for nuclear weapons, which worried leaders in Washington and U.S. allies in the Middle East. At the same time, groups supported by Iran had attacked American soldiers in Iraq and Syria multiple times, and Iran was reportedly involved in drone attacks against oil facilities in Saudi Arabia. The situation kept getting more dangerous as both countries retaliated against each other. Iran captured oil tankers in the Persian Gulf, while the United States sent more military forces to the region. Diplomacy had basically stopped and the two countries were both not willing to take the first step to calm the tensions. This combination of ongoing hostility and Iran's progress on its nuclear program set the stage for Trump's decision to order military strikes. From this point of view, Trump's 2025 strike on Iran's nuclear facilities shows that there is still a long-running tension between the US and Iran. It also shows Trump's political goals domestically, by helping project western strength and power as well as shifting public attention from domestic issues such as political issues. This decision goes along with the age-old U.S. security doctrine of coercive deterrence, but also was influenced by short-term political goals as described by Byman and Waxman (2000), who argue that U.S. military actions in the Middle East are often meant to show strength, prove to allies that America will protect them, and stop enemies from becoming more powerful. Trump's 2025 strike shows how all five factors of strategic enmity come together. Political incentives motivated the decision, historical grievances

gave more of a background into how both sides interpreted it, the different identity narratives shaped the public's justifications and psychological misperceptions, and finally the cycle of strike and then retaliation showed the security dilemma in action.

Ramazani's (2004) framework also helps to make sense of why Iran has some of its reactions to rising tensions. He argues that Iranian leaders go back and forth between ideological resistance and partially compromising. Each time, they adjust their plan of action based on the international structure. When outside threats start the Iranian leaders bring back their principles to keep their domestic support as well as their legitimacy. This pattern of rallying around a national identity and core values during times of external pressure is not unique to Iran. When governments feel threatened by outside forces it's common for them to remind their citizens of their country's core values and beliefs to bring people together and gain support for their decisions. Countries like the U.S. during the Cold War, Russia when facing Western sanctions, and China when dealing with international pressure have all used this same strategy. On the other hand, Iran can also show that it can switch its course through limited cooperation. This constant back and forth supports Emery's (2013) and Byman and Waxman's (2000) arguments that hostility between the United States and Iran is prolonged because both countries don't understand each other's intentions, along with their actions. Each country interprets the decisions that the other makes as hostile rather than trying to move past it. As a result, certain policy decisions, such as sanctions, military strikes, or diplomatic talks, continue to happen due to the rising tensions and mistrust as previously described by scholars.

When using the same framework to view more recent events, it is clear that the strikes by President Trump are a continuation of historical patterns of U.S. policy towards Iran. When looking at the strike through this lens, Trump's decision to strike Iranian nuclear facilities serves

two purposes. The first is that the strike showed that the US is willing to use force if needed to project power. The U.S. and the Trump Administration deem it necessary in order to coerce Iran to stop allegedly enriching uranium in order to produce nuclear weapons. The second is that it shifts attention away from domestic problems and the possibility of approval ratings declining. Iran responded by launching missiles at U.S. bases in Qatar showing it was willing to retaliate against external attacks. This response shows Iran's narrative of their identity of resistance to Western domination. It also shows the security dilemma because Iran viewed retaliation as a defensive necessity to deter future attacks while the U.S. saw it as confirmation that Iran was acting in an aggressive way. The fact that these patterns keep happening shows that the older theories still explain recent events well, even though the events themselves have changed.

When looking at this pattern over a long period of time, it is apparent that the indecisiveness in U.S. policy and Iran's shifts from cooperation to defiance follow the same pattern. Iran showed willingness to cooperate during key moments such as President Khatami's reform period in the late 1990s and during the negotiations that led to the 2015 nuclear deal. With that being said, Iran shifted toward defiance when the United States failed to follow through on diplomatic openings or when American actions pointed toward regime change as the end goal. Part of this tension comes from the U.S. desire to promote liberal democracy and Western political values in the Middle East, which Iranian leaders view as an attempt to undermine their Islamic Republic system and replace it with a Western-style government. This ideological clash between Iran's revolutionary anti-Western identity and America's promotion of democratic governance has continuously made it hard for cooperation efforts. For the U.S., the history of mistrust and pressures from elections domestically puts a halt to diplomacy before it can have a chance to move forward. On the other hand, for Iran, feeling ostracized from a

Western-focused global structure keeps it constantly on the back foot and defending. This is true even when Iran's retaliations seem aggressive, as demonstrated in the retaliatory strikes on U.S. bases in 2025.

People also often see the constant tension between the U.S. and Iran as a sign that their relationship is politically stuck and that it is not possible to move forward. The tension between the U.S. and Iran is described as an “exception cycle” by Fawcett and Payne (2023), where both Iran and the U.S. keep going back to the same patterns. The reason for this, according to Fawcett and Payne, is that each changing administration thinks that it can be the one that finally stops the hostility, but in reality, they end up prolonging it. In Meyers' review of Obama's 2010 Nuclear posture review, we see that he describes Obama's approach as “domestic diplomacy.” The Obama administration wanted to rebuild diplomacy through the JCPOA (Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action), which was a 2015 agreement between Iran and six world powers, including the United States. The deal required Iran to limit its nuclear program and reduce its uranium stockpile. To add on to this it asked for international inspections in exchange for a halt to economic sanctions that had severely damaged Iran's economy. But, even after the deal was signed, the Obama administration kept some sanctions in place to show strength and avoid looking weak at home in the U.S. Using the same coercive tactics, the Trump administration reimposed sanctions on Iran and withdrew from the deal in 2018, aiming to fix what he saw as Obama's overly forgiving approach. Trump and his supporters argued that the JCPOA was too lenient because it only restricted Iran's nuclear activities temporarily, didn't address the ballistic missile program in Iran, and also failed to stop Iran from supporting militant groups across the Middle East. They believed the deal gave Iran too much sanctions relief without demanding enough concessions in return. More recently, the Biden administration promised to work toward

improved relations with Iran and more diplomacy, which resulted in a few sanctions being lifted. Each U.S. administration has repeated the same cycle of trying to engage and be cooperative with Iran and trying to deter it. Even though each new president says they will handle Iran differently, both Democratic and Republican administrations usually end up doing the same things. No matter the party, U.S. presidents switch back and forth between trying diplomacy and then going back to pressure, usually with sanctions or threats. This happens because the United States encounters the same problems and political pressures every time, which makes it hard for any president to take a completely new approach. In the end, both parties repeat the same cycle, just in slightly different ways. This shows that election politics and divisions in the government domestically have kept reinforcing the same patterns that Ramazani (2004) and Emery (2013) described, further proving their framework to describe more recent events in the U.S.-Iran relationship.

In this way, the election cycle in the U.S. is like a force that recreates cycles, similar to the “security dilemma” in classical realism. When a presidential administration tries to show that they are open to diplomatic talks, its political rivals try to make that look like a weakness. As a result, they push the administration after them to react with more hostile sanctions and military action. A perfect example of this is Obama's 2015 nuclear deal and Trump's decision, and then Trump's response to undo the nuclear deal, shows this pattern. This is what Fawcett and Payne (2023) describe as a cycle of U.S. policy. Short periods of diplomatic talks rarely last long enough to go into a second term of presidency in the U.S.. The government structure is still slow and indecisive on policy, as noted in the 1980s by Emery (2013), but now it mixes with the uncertainty of election cycles. When all of these forces come together, it creates a pattern where the leaders, who are feeling pressure and uncertainty at home, want to respond by taking harder

positions on foreign policy. So, even when the world is constantly changing, the theories that show the domestic political limits and internal government divisions still explain the U.S.–Iran relations very effectively. Additionally, international events and global community responses shape U.S. policy decisions. For example, pressure from European allies who wanted to preserve the JCPOA may have influenced the Biden administration's approach to Iran negotiations. To add to this, other regional events like Iranian attacks on international shipping in the Strait of Hormuz or Iran's involvement in conflicts in Syria and Yemen created international concerns that U.S. leaders had to address. Global discussions at the United Nations and among Western allies about Iran's nuclear program also affected how American politicians framed their policies domestically.

VI. Economic Sanctions and their Effects

The constant use of sanctions as a primary U.S. strategy shows how this long term pattern continues on. Sanctions against Iran first started in 1979 after the Iranian Revolution, when Iranian students took American diplomats hostage in the U.S. Embassy in Tehran. These early sanctions froze Iranian government money held in the United States and stopped most trade between the two countries. Specifically President Carter issued Executive Order 12170 on November 14, 1979 which froze around \$12 billion in Iranian government assets which were being held in American banks. The U.S. also banned all imports from Iran, including oil, and prohibited American companies from doing business with Tehran (Maloney 2015). To fully understand the sanctions regime against Iran, it is important to place it within the broader context of Cold War international relations.

During the Cold War, Iran was a key U.S. ally in the Middle East under the Shah. It served as a kind of buffer zone between Soviet expansion into the Persian Gulf region. The United States helped Iran develop its nuclear program in the 1950s and 1960s under the "Atoms for Peace" initiative by providing Tehran with its first research reactor in 1967. But, the 1979 Islamic Revolution transformed Iran from a close American ally into a revolutionary state that was opposed to U.S. influence in the region. This shift occurred at a very important part of the Cold War. This was when the Soviet Union had just invaded Afghanistan and the United States was losing its influence across the Middle East. The hostage crisis that came after made Iran a kind of symbol of American humiliation and contributed to President Carter's electoral defeat. After the Cold War ended in 1991, the United States came to be the main superpower and took on a strategy of "containment" toward both Iran and Iraq, seeking to prevent either country from dominating the oil-rich Persian Gulf. This post-Cold War framework shaped how the United States approached Iran's nuclear program in the 2000s not as a nonproliferation issue but as part of a more general effort to keep the American hegemony in the Middle East.

Over the years, sanctions grew much larger and became a lot more complicated, especially in the early 2000s when worries increased about Iran developing nuclear weapons. The crisis escalated in August 2002 when an Iranian exile group called the National Council of Resistance of Iran (NCRI) showed that Iran had been secretly building two major nuclear facilities. One of them was a uranium enrichment plant at Natanz and a heavy water production facility at Arak (Iran Watch 2017). The International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) had not been informed about these sites, which was a violation of Iran's obligations under the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty. IAEA Director General Mohamed ElBaradei visited Natanz in February 2003 and found 160 centrifuges complete and ready for operation, with 1,000 more

under construction. During subsequent inspections, IAEA inspectors found traces of highly enriched uranium on centrifuge machines even though Iran claimed it had not enriched any uranium at the site. These discoveries raised serious suspicions about Iran's intentions.

Understanding why Iran pursued its nuclear program helps explain why sanctions have failed to change Tehran's behavior. Iran's nuclear ambitions stem from multiple factors. First, from a realist perspective, Iran is surrounded by nuclear-armed or nuclear-capable neighbors, Israel, Pakistan, and Russia, and has faced threats from the United States which invaded two of Iran's neighbors in Afghanistan in 2001 and Iraq in 2003. In this type of global environment, Iranian leaders view nuclear capability as essential for deterrence and regime survival. To add on to this, from a constructivist perspective Iran's nuclear program has a lot to do with national identity and pride. Iran sees itself as a great civilization with a right to advanced technology, and Iranian leaders frame the nuclear program as a symbol of scientific achievement and independence from Western control. Supreme Leader Khomeini opposed the nuclear program at first, but the Iran-Iraq War convinced Iranian leaders that they could not rely on international law or Western powers for protection. Third, the nuclear program serves domestic political purposes. Iranian leaders use the nuclear program to rally the nationalist sentiment in their country and portray the Western opposition as simply an attempt to keep Iran weak and dependent. Ramazani (2004) explains that Iran's foreign policy is a mix of ideological resistance and pragmatic cooperation. He also adds that the nuclear program fits both goals. It shows resistance to Western pressure and also serves as a something that can be used in negotiations. This explains why Iran has been willing to negotiate limits on its program, for example in the 2015 JCPOA, but they were unwilling to abandon it entirely in the end. The program is a major part of Iran's security strategy and national identity.

The risks that are posed by Iran's nuclear program alarmed the international community for a lot of different reasons. First, the nuclear proliferation in the Middle East could end up triggering an arms race in the region where Saudi Arabia, Turkey, and Egypt could possibly seek their own nuclear weapons to counter Iran. Second, Iran's ballistic missile program with nuclear capability added onto that would give Tehran the ability to threaten Israel, U.S. military bases in the region, and Gulf allies like Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates with the range of the missiles. Another aspect was that the international community worried that nuclear materials or technology could fall into the hands of non-state actors due to Iran's relationships with groups like Hezbollah and Hamas. One of the biggest reasons was also that a nuclear armed Iran would change the balance of power in the Middle East which could give power to Tehran to act more aggressively in conflicts in Syria, Yemen, and Iraq. All of these different risks show why the United Nations made Iran's nuclear program a top priority and why the international community was willing to impose strict sanctions even though there were economic costs.

In September 2005, the IAEA Board of Governors found that Iran was in noncompliance with its safeguards agreement for the first time. The case was referred to the UN Security Council in February 2006. This began a series of increasingly strict UN sanctions: First UN Security Council Resolution 1737 was passed unanimously on December 23, 2006. This resolution banned the supply of nuclear related technology and materials to Iran. It froze the assets of 12 individuals and 10 entities connected to Iran's nuclear and missile programs, and established the "1737 Committee" to monitor implementation (Arms Control Association 2016). Then, Resolution 1747 followed on March 24, 2007 which expanded the sanctions. This resolution imposed an arms embargo prohibiting member states from buying weapons from Iran, expanded the asset freeze to include 15 more individuals and 13 additional entities, and

specifically targeted members of the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC), including Qasem Soleimani who is the commander of the Quds Force (UN Security Council 2007).

The Third, Resolution 1803 was adopted on March 3, 2008. This resolution had more effect on assets and made it so that states had to inspect Iranian ships and aircraft suspected of carrying prohibited cargo, imposed travel bans on sanctioned individuals, and added 13 more individuals and 12 more entities to the sanctions list (Arms Control Association 2016). Then Resolution 1929 was passed on June 9, 2010. This resolution was the strongest of all of them and it banned Iran from any activities related to ballistic missiles capable of delivering nuclear weapons. It also banned all Iranian investment in uranium mining, it expanded the arms embargo, and it targeted 40 additional companies including major Iranian banks and shipping companies (UN Security Council 2010). The international community played a critical role in pressuring Iran through different institutions. The IAEA was the main monitoring group which did regular inspections of Iran's declared nuclear facilities and reported violations to its Board of Governors. When the IAEA found Iran in noncompliance in 2005, it referred the case to the UN Security Council, which then became the enforcement mechanism for international sanctions. The Security Council's five permanent members, the United States, United Kingdom, France, Russia, and China, which are all known as P5+1, led diplomatic efforts to negotiate with Iran. But, the international community was very divided. Russia and China which had economic ties with Iran frequently pushed for weaker sanctions and delayed action. This division within the international community meant that sanctions were often weaker than the United States wanted which led Washington to impose its own sanctions on top of the UN ones. The EU also imposed its own sanctions, including an oil embargo in 2012 that significantly reduced Iran's oil exports to

Europe. The fact that there were international, regional, and unilateral sanctions put a lot of economic pressure on Iran.

There are two main types of sanctions that are used against Iran. The first are U.S. sanctions, and the second are UN sanctions, and they work differently. U.S. sanctions are created by the U.S. government acting alone and are usually stronger and cover different aspects of Iran's economy. For example, the Comprehensive Iran Sanctions, Accountability, and Divestment Act (CISADA), signed into law in 2010, targeted Iran's oil exports, banking system, and shipping industry. These sanctions cut Iran's oil exports from approximately 2.5 million barrels per day in 2011 to around 1 million barrels per day by 2014, costing Iran an estimated \$50 billion in lost revenue (Maloney 2015). The sanctions also cut Iran off from the SWIFT international banking system, making it nearly impossible for Iran to conduct international financial transactions. These sanctions even include secondary sanctions, which means the United States punishes other countries' companies if they do business with Iran, making it extremely difficult for Iran to trade with anyone. UN sanctions, on the other hand, need approval from the Security Council and are usually a lot more limited in what they target. The UN sanctions usually focus on more specific aspects like nuclear materials or weapons sales, whereas U.S. sanctions are harder to remove because they are connected to American politics and what voters think about America having a hardline stance on Iran. On top of this, the UN sanctions can be changed more easily through international agreements when multiple countries agree to adjust them.

The sanctions policy demonstrates all of the factors that sustain the U.S.-Iran strategic enmity. First, sanctions serve political incentives for leaders on both sides. In the United States, imposing sanctions allows politicians to appear tough on Iran without going to war which is politically popular domestically. Wang et al. (2024) explain that leaders use foreign tensions to

rally support domestically. In Iran the sanctions give leaders an enemy to blame for economic the problems that they are facing which distracts the citizens from government failures and unites them against a common threat.

Despite these various types and cycles of sanctions, earlier studies focused on the “rally-around-the-flag” effect, but newer research shows that the sanctions also work to strengthen the power structure and lock them in place, making political change much harder. RezaeeDaryakenari et al. (2024) put forth the idea that sanctions haven’t just created temporary national unity but that they have permanently shaped Iran’s political and economic system. Their research shows that sanctions that target key parts of the economy, such as the oil industry, banking sector, and international trade networks, actually make Tehran's elites more powerful by changing who has control over money and resources. This explains why Iran engages in this pattern. Sanctions shift economic control to networks aligned with the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) and regime loyalists, who profit from smuggling and black-market trade that sanctions create. Sanctions shift control into networks that are aligned or directly linked to Iran's Elites. So this has the opposite effect of weakening and dividing the regime, the sanctions actually strengthen its ability to help its loyal supporters stop opposition from becoming strong enough. This supports Ramazani’s (2004) argument that Iran’s defensive behavior isn’t just because of its post-revolutionary ideology but that it’s also a response to being shut out of the world’s main systems of trade.

Sanctions make Iran’s exclusion permanent by building it into global systems, this keeps Iran in the same place that the country’s early revolutionary leaders tried to challenge. Examples of this include Supreme Leader Khomeini, who describes standing up to Western control as a religious duty. Abbasi (2025) adds to this and says that the Iranian civilian population losing

control and giving the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps more resources and control has increased their power and influence. The sanctions end up strengthening Iran's authoritarian rule and making the chances for reform or political change slim to nothing. So therefore, what seems like a short term Western strategy of using economic pressure actually ends up strengthening the regime and its ideology. This means that sanctions are actually failing to achieve one of the West's main goals in the region, which is to spread liberal democracy and Western political values to Iran.

Western policymakers hoped that economic pressure would create such difficult conditions that the Iranian people would demand change and push for a more democratic government that looked more like Western systems. The U.S assumed that suffering under sanctions would make Iranians blame their own government and make them want reforms that aligned with Western democratic ideals like free elections and individual freedoms. To the dismay of American politicians, the reality of the situation has been completely different. Instead of weakening the authoritarian system and making democratic processes possible the sanctions have actually made the government stronger. The economic setbacks have not led to democratic reform but instead they have led to more control in Iran. Sanctions have made it easier for Iranian leaders to blame enemies for the country's problems rather than taking responsibility themselves. This outcome is the opposite of what Western countries were wanting which shows that the strategy of using economic pressure to promote democracy in Iran has backfired heavily.

The usefulness of earlier frameworks like Emery's (2013) view of divided U.S. policymaking and Ramazani's (2004) concept of Iran's structural isolation is on full display here. Sanctions keep being used because they meet the political needs of each country. In the U.S., sanctions make leaders look strong for domestic approval while not having to start an all-out war.

On the other hand, the U.S. gives Tehran a reason to tighten control of the economy and claims it's part of defending its country. Both countries are using the same cycle of mistrust to strengthen their domestic support and access to power at home. The fact that the cycle of sanctions and resistance keeps going on goes to show that the old ideas used to explain the hostility still work. This shows that the habits that the government has and the political pressures that they employ are usually a byproduct of bad cost-benefit thinking and not thoroughly thinking through cause and effect. The leaders in both countries are hindered by their own domestic expectation, their ideology, and their fear of illegitimacy on a global scale. So, the cycle of sanctions and the economic responses to those sanctions are more about remaining legitimate than finding new and better strategies that might work better.

VII. Iran's Changing Global Relationships

The basic patterns of power have not gone away on a global level. Instead, there have been new factors added to the mix. Bazoobandi (2024) shows that Iran's foreign policy has changed over time and adapted to a world that is shaped by China's growing power and the ideas of a relatively declining U.S. influence globally. Iranian leaders see the shifting U.S. global policy as a sign of weakness and have consequently strengthened their ties with China, Russia, and Saudi Arabia through Chinese mediation. Bazoobandi (2024) calls this the "geography of resistance," and he tries to explain why this is a strategy that Iran uses to try and push back against Western dominance. By changing the structure of international relations, by increasing ties with eastern influences, Iran can make advances without directly engaging in conflict with the U.S..

This idea is similar to Ramazani's (2004) earlier view that Iran tried to gain independence while in a world led by Western powers, but since then, the overall global structure

has shifted and new relationships have formed. Iran's resistance is now part of a larger narrative of countries coming together to oppose Western dominance. The U.S. is still stuck in its old strategy of using force and threats. The U.S.'s reaction to Iran's relations with China and Russia is new sanctions and increased military pressure. When all of these forces come together, such as America's slow policy changes, China's growing power, and Iran's taking advantage of new relationships, it also shows that older theories still make sense. It's not because the ideas haven't changed, but because the world's structure of power in international relations has only changed a little, not completely. Iran's role in Chinese-led peace talks in the Gulf, as well as the fact that it supplies drones to Russia, shows that it has some independence in making choices, but that it also depends on powerful partners to pursue its goals. Iran's leaders are trying to push back against the old global system by becoming part of a growing new one. The thing that stays the same is not who's involved, but the pattern of adapting to change while being limited by an imbalance of power.

VIII. Recent Events and Analysis

From 2018 to 2025, the U.S. pulled out of the JCPOA, which clearly supports the older theories about the U.S.-Iran relations that still help explain what's happening today. Rees (2023) sees the fall of the JCPOA as a sign of America's inner struggle in its foreign policy. There is a constant back and forth between wanting to lead the world and trying not to appear weak or illegitimate. A constant swing between wanting to lead the world and being afraid of showing weakness. Every U.S. administration tries to show strength through powerful speeches, sanctions, and military action. The Trump administration's maximum pressure stance in its campaign and Trump's rhetoric on nuclear issues are not new strategies, they are a direct repeat

of historical fears and ongoing patterns that have been changed to fit a world where the U.S. is increasingly losing momentum compared to the post-Cold War era.

The U.S. decision to undo the JCPOA also shows Emery's (2013) point about how government divisions and lack of coordination keep leading to inconsistent foreign policy. Even though many of the U.S. defense officials knew that leaving the deal would strengthen Iran's revolutionary thinking, the government's indecisive decision-making and focus on short-term domestic politics still won in the end. At the same time, in Iran, the abandonment of the deal shows that Iran shifted between stricter religious and patriotic ideology and practical cooperation. The strong believers used revolutionary slogans to regain support domestically, and moderate-leaning diplomats lost the influence they needed to try to allow for more dialogue and compromise between the two countries. This mistrust is then made worse with the increasing global uncertainty of hegemonic powers. In the end, the JCPOA situation shows that the U.S. and Iran are stuck in the same loop of structural patterns.

The U.S. still views its relationship with Iran to be about controlling threats and getting the right political timing around elections. At the same time, Iran continues to see U.S. policy-making and actions as an indication that the West cannot be trusted. The reason these patterns continue is not because the theories are outdated, but instead because the actual policies are keeping the same distance between the two countries when it comes to diplomacy. The same power structures and fears that emerged during the Cold War and post-revolutionary period are still at play. The continuation of this relationship between deterrence and cooperation, even though the world has advanced so much in the past years, has a basic foundation of mistrust that is still mostly the same.

When all of these aspects come together, the exception cycle in U.S. politics, the impact of sanctions, Iran's shift in strategy in relationships, and the struggles of legitimacy for both countries continue to perpetuate the short times of stability and the major events of change in the U.S.-Iran relationship. Scholars such as Ramazani (2004), Emery (2013), and Byman & Waxman (2000) did not just explain the past, their studies are still valuable ways to look at how countries deal with being left out of global systems as well as divisions within their own governments. So even in 2025, with the power balance of countries in the world shifting, the theories are essential. They show that the U.S.-Iran conflict isn't just a new problem that a certain administration has brought about, but an ongoing pattern of systems that are cemented in and political decisions that have gone on for around 50 years.

VII. Regional Dynamics of Iraq, Saddam Hussein, and Israel

To fully understand U.S.-Iran hostility, we need to look at how other countries in the region have shaped the conflict. Two actors have been especially important: Iraq under Saddam Hussein and Israel. The Iran-Iraq War from 1980 to 1988 changed everything for U.S.-Iran relations. Takeyh (2010) explains that when Saddam Hussein invaded Iran, the United States supported Iraq because it saw Iran's new revolutionary government as the bigger threat. The U.S. gave Iraq intelligence, weapons, and money. According to declassified CIA documents, the United States provided Iraq with satellite imagery and maps showing Iranian troop positions, knowing that Iraq would use chemical weapons against those troops (Foreign Policy 2013). Iraq used mustard gas and sarin nerve agent against Iranian soldiers, killing an estimated 7,500 Iranians and injuring thousands more (Al Jazeera 2018). The Reagan administration knew about these attacks as early as 1983 but did not stop supporting Iraq because, as one U.S. official said,

they "were desperate to make sure that Iraq did not lose" (Foreign Policy 2013). For Iranians, this was proof that America cared more about hurting Iran than about doing the right thing.

	Oppose Kurdish Safe Haven	Oppose Shi'a Safe Haven	Refuse to Accept UNSCOM Inspections (1991–1992)	Initiate 1993 UNSCOM NFZ Standoff	Initiate 1994 UNSCOM/ 1996 Incursion into the North	Initiate 1997–1998 UNSCOM Standoff	Initiate December 1998 Strike
Rebuild conventional forces							
Maintain NBC arsenal			X	X		X	X
End diplomatic isolation						X	
End sanctions			X		X	X	X
Improve regional influence (threats or accomplishments)				X			
Improve prestige at home	X	X			X	X	X
Strengthen control over Iraq	X	X			X		

Figure 5.1—Saddam's Primary Objectives, by Case

As Figure 5.1 shows, Saddam had several goals including keeping his weapons, ending sanctions, and staying in power.

RAND/MR1146/5.2

	Establish Kurdish Safe Haven	Establish Shi'a Safe Haven	Force Acceptance of UNSCOM Inspections (1991–1992)	1992–1993 UNSCOM NFZ Standoff	1994 Border Buildup	1996 Incursion into the North	1997–1998 UNSCOM Standoff	December 1998 Strike
Keep Iraqi conventional forces weak								X
Halt Iraqi NBC programs			X	X			X	X
Remove Saddam from power	X ^a							X
Protect subjugated Iraqi peoples	X	X				X		
Ensure security of Gulf allies (from immediate threat)		X			X			
Minimize U.S. casualties ^b						X		
Maintain sanctions							X	
Prevent destabilization of allies	X				X	X	X	X
Maintain Iraq's diplomatic isolation						X	X	

^aRemoving Saddam from power did not motivate the creation of the northern protective zone, but, once created, this zone was exploited for anti-Saddam activities.

^bMinimizing U.S. casualties is a high priority for any U.S. military operation. This is listed as a category here for cases when the political leadership sought to prevent any casualties, even if it severely constrained operations.

Figure 5.2—U.S. Objectives That Affected the Use of Force, by Case

Figure 5.2 shows what the U.S. wanted, including stopping Iraq's weapons programs and protecting Gulf allies. Byman and Waxman (2000) explain that the U.S. used both deterrence and compellence by forcing him to change as shown in Figure 2.1.

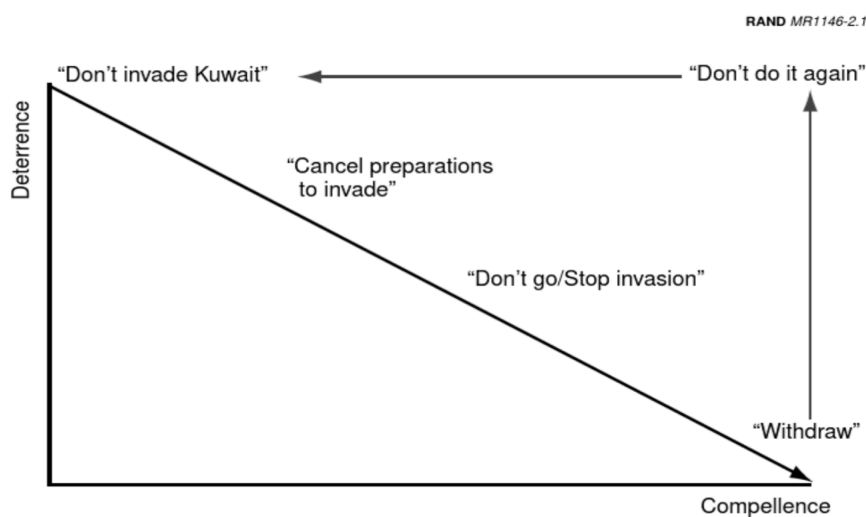


Figure 2.1—Deterrence and Compellence Blur in Practice

When the United States invaded Iraq in 2003 and removed Saddam, Iran got stronger. Kirmanj and Sadq (2018) show that with its biggest enemy gone Iran and its influence got bigger in Iraq through political ties and support for militias. The American invasion, which was supposed to make the region more stable actually ended up helping Iran.

Israel's Role

Israel has also shaped U.S.-Iran relations. Since 1979, Iran has refused to recognize Israel and has supported groups like Hezbollah and Hamas that fight against Israel. Iranian leaders use anti-Israel speeches to build support at home. For the United States, protecting Israel is a key part of its Middle East policy. The Center for Preventive Action (2025) documents how tensions between Iran and Israel have increased over the years. When Iran builds missiles that could reach Israel or supports groups that attack Israel, American leaders feel pressure to respond with

sanctions or threats. Israel has pushed the U.S. to take a hard line on Iran's nuclear program, saying a nuclear Iran would be a major threat to Israel's existence.

Israel has also taken action against Iran's nuclear program. In 2010 a computer virus called Stuxnet, developed by the United States and Israel, infected Iran's Natanz nuclear facility and destroyed around 1,000 centrifuges (IEEE Spectrum 2013). In 2025, Israel launched attacks on Iranian nuclear sites calling it Operation Rising Lion. These actions increased tensions between the U.S. and Iran because Iran sees Israel and America as working together. Iraq and Israel show how regional dynamics feed into the different factors of strategic enmity. The Iran-Iraq War created historical grievances that Iranians still remember and especially the feeling that America helped Saddam use chemical weapons against them. The presence of Israeli and American military power feeds the security dilemma and leaders in all three countries gain political benefits when they portray the others as enemies. It is hard to fix due to a whole region with different variables.

IX. Synthesis: How the Factors Interact

After looking into the history, the sanctions, and the recent events, it is more clear to see how the factors of strategic enmity work together to keep the U.S.-Iran hostility going. These factors don't work alone, they feed into each other and make the conflict very hard to fix. Political incentives start a cycle where the leaders on both sides benefit from keeping the conflict going. In the United States politicians who act tough on Iran get more support from voters whereas on the other hand leaders who try diplomacy get called weak. In Iran the Supreme Leader and the Revolutionary Guard use the American hostility to be able to stay in power and blame the outsiders and Westerners for the country's problems.

This is another example of what Wang et al. (2024) call the "rally around the flag" effect because powerful people on both sides benefit from conflict; they don't have major reasons to try to push for peace. To add onto this, historical grievances give leaders the stories they need to try to justify the hostility. Iranians look at the 1953 coup and the collapse of the JCPOA as proof that America cannot be trusted. Americans look at the 1979 hostage crisis and Iran's support for groups like Hezbollah as proof that Iran is dangerous.

All of these grievances come together to give each country their own narratives that make compromise feel wrong. For Iran, standing up to America is a core part of what it means to be the Islamic Republic. For America, confronting Iran is tied to its role as the defender of global order and protector of allies in the Middle East. Wendt (1992) argues that these identities are built through years of hostile interactions and when identity is at stake compromise feels like betrayal so the leaders on both sides end up avoiding it. This leads to deep mistrust, where each side assumes the worst about the other. Even when one side makes a genuine attempt at peace, the other side views it with suspicion. When President Khatami reached out to America in the late 1990s, U.S. officials questioned whether it was real. When President Obama negotiated the JCPOA, Iranian hardliners warned that America would break its promises which seemed to come true when Trump pulled out of the deal.

Finally, the security dilemma locks everything in place. When America adds sanctions or sends more troops to the region, it sees these actions as defensive. But Iran sees them as threats and responds by building up its nuclear program. When Iran advances its nuclear program, it sees this as protection. But America sees it as proof that Iran is dangerous and adds more pressure. Each side's attempts to defend itself make the other

side feel more threatened, creating a cycle that feeds itself. these five factors create what this paper calls strategic enmity where political incentives, historical grievances, identity narratives, mistrust, and the security dilemma all push towards continued conflict. This is why U.S.-Iran hostility has lasted over 70 years through many different presidents and world conditions. The 2015 JCPOA showed that these barriers can be temporarily overcome, but its collapse shows how fragile any progress will be without addressing the deeper factors that keep the cycle going.

X. Counterarguments and Limitations

This paper argues that U.S.-Iran hostility continues because of strategic enmity but there have been times when the two countries worked together, which shows that change is possible. The 2015 JCPOA is the best example of this. When leaders on both sides saw benefits in making a deal, they were able to put aside decades of mistrust and come to an agreement. For almost three years, Iran followed the rules of the deal and the United States gave Iran relief from sanctions. This shows that the cycle of hostility can be broken when the conditions are right. It is also true that voters don't always want conflict. President Obama worked hard to get the JCPOA done even when many people in Congress were against it. In Iran, President Rouhani won his election by promising to work with the West. This shows that leaders who talk about diplomacy as a strength, not a weakness, can get support from their people. This paper also has some limits. It mostly looks at decisions made by the US and Iran and doesn't go as deep into countries like Israel, Saudi Arabia, and the Gulf states and their political decisions

XI. Conclusion

The relationship between the United States and Iran is one of the longest and most dangerous rivalries in the world today. This paper asked the simple question of why does U.S.-Iran hostility keep going even when leaders change, the world changes, and both sides try to make peace? The answer is what this paper calls strategic enmity, a cycle of hostility that keeps feeding itself because of connected factors.

Political incentives reward leaders on both sides for keeping the conflict going. Historical grievances give them stories to justify the hostility. Narratives make compromise feel like betrayal. Mistrust makes each side assume the worst about the other and the security dilemma makes every defensive action look like an attack which keeps the cycle going. These factors make the conflict very hard to stop. This explains why U.S.-Iran hostility has lasted over 70 years through many different presidents and very different world conditions. It also explains why the 2015 JCPOA fell apart so quickly. The deal was a really big achievement but it didn't change the political incentives, or the mistrust that keeps the conflict alive.

Looking to the future this suggests that without fixing the deeper problems, future attempts at peace will face the same challenges. New presidents will promise new approaches but will run into the same walls. Moments of cooperation will be weak and easy to undo. And the cycle of sanctions, military threats, and fighting back will continue. The U.S.-Iran conflict is not just a problem that the right leader or the right policy can fix. It is built into the politics, history, and fears of both countries. Understanding this is the

first step toward finding ways to change the relationship from strategic enmity into something more stable and less hostile.

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